

A Short Story: In Philpot Lane [C2]

A Londra, una piccola statua di due topolini che mangiano del formaggio onora la memoria di due operai che trasformarono un'antipatia personale in una tragedia.

Bob reached the top of the ladder just as dawn appeared on the eastern horizon. The air was ice cold and frost gleamed on the wooden planks of the scaffolding. He was glad of his gloves. Bob always arrived before the other builders so that he could hide his knapsack. He never talked much to the other workmen on any site, but this time it was worse. Jem, the gang leader, was a cocky, belligerent man, who had taken against Bob and used him as the butt of his jokes. He'd twice hidden Bob's knapsack and Bob was sure that Jem had taken his best chisel. The other builders also resented the compliments Bob received from the Master Mason. Bob opened his knapsack and took out his tools, slotting the chisels into his belt and weighing the sturdy mallet lovingly in his hand. Made of gleaming lignum vitae, the head was small, but the dense wood was heavy and powerful. Leaving his flask of beer and his lunch of bread and cheese inside, he rolled the canvas knapsack into a tight bundle and stowed it carefully under a plank, away from vermin — both rodent and human. As Bob set to work finishing off a piece of delicate moulding, the sky brightened steadily and the rumble of cartwheels drifted up from Eastcheap. Just as the sun flamed up over the docks, Jem's fleshy face appeared at the top of the ladder. "Well, look who's here! Bootlicker Bob is hard at work, boys!" "All right, Jem?" Bob knew it was best not to react. "Oh, I'm all right, what about you? You left your missus all cold and alone so early in the morning? I'd better send young Nat round to warm her up!" Young Nat, the youngest builder in the gang, had just climbed up behind Jem and his face split into a grin. Luckily there came a sharp whistle from the street. Jem peered over the edge. "Ready, Joe!" He turned to Bob. "Joe and Frank have got some Portland on the hoist; give us a hand, will you?" Bob nodded and followed Jem to the top of the hoist. Two skinny rats streaked along one of the uprights. Bob lashed out with his lignum vitae hammer, missing the rats completely and skidding slightly on the frozen planks. He wished he'd

been aiming for Jem's head. He, Jem and Nat guided the bucket of cement onto the scaffolding. "You two take this round to the Philpot Lane side," said Jem. "What about you?" Bob never liked leaving his knapsack when Jem was around. "There's another bucket coming!" Jem glared at him. So Bob and Nat inched the heavy bucket along the platform. By the time they got back to the hoist, Joe and Frank were standing at the top of the ladder gazing at Jem, who seemed to be returning from the other end of the platform where Bob had been working. Jem grinned. "Rats! I hate them!" he said loudly. "Just kicked those two into the Thames." He saw Bob's expression and frowned. "Something wrong, Bob?" Bob shook his head and marched to his end of the scaffolding. Behind him, the other men laughed. Fiction

A Short Story: Postcard Una cartolina anonima dà libero sfogo all'immaginazione della nostra protagonista. Sarà pronta a conoscere la verità? Rachel Roberts, Rachel Roberts "He hides his knapsack!" Jem mocked. "Thinks we're going to nick his stuff!" Bob checked on his knapsack as soon as the other men were busy. It was still there. He began to chisel away at the moulding, finishing off any rough edges. It was the job the Mason had given him because he had a delicate hand and was patient. The work was absorbing and he soon forgot about Jem and the others. He glanced up only once at the sound of pattering feet — the rats Jem was supposed to have kicked into the Thames, but evidently hadn't. He didn't look up again until the bell of St. Magnus's church told him it was time for lunch. He pulled his gloves off with his teeth, untied his knapsack and sat on the edge of the platform. He took a long drink of beer and realised he was starving! Reaching again into his pack, he felt for his bread and cheese — they were gone. Jem! Bob flung down his knapsack and marched, lignum vitae mallet in hand, to the other end of the platform where the others were eating their own sandwiches. "Jem!" Bob shouted. "Where's my bloody lunch?" Jem looked up, outraged. "You calling me a thief?" Bob smacked the mallet into the palm of his hand. "I know you took it!" Jem leapt to his feet and marched towards him, but Bob was ready. He smacked Jem on the arm with his mallet. Jem roared and launched himself at Bob. For a minute they fought furiously, until Jem seized hold of Bob's arm and wrenched the mallet from his grasp. The effort sent him sliding backwards over the icy planks. He skidded to the edge of the

scaffolding, still clutching Bob's sleeve, and slipped right over. Feeling himself dragged towards the edge, Bob grabbed one of the steel uprights, but it was wet with melted frost. His ungloved fingers slipped straight off and the two men tumbled through the air with an ear-splitting scream. Nat, Frank and Joe sat frozen to the spot. They were too shocked to notice the scampering of tiny feet as two skinny rats tussled triumphantly with a hunk of bread and cheese.

THE TWO MICE EATING CHEESE

On a building in Philpot Lane in London, on the corner of Eastcheap Street, the city's smallest public sculpture can be found. It depicts two mice eating cheese, and supposedly commemorates the death of a workman, or possibly two workmen, who are said to have fallen from scaffolding on the site. According to some, this happened during the construction of the building that hosts the sculpture, in 1862. Legend has it that the workmen were arguing over the theft of a sandwich, which was later revealed to have been taken by mice.

Glossary

- **frowned** = aggrottare le sopracciglia
- **leapt to his feet** = balzare in piedi
- **slipped right over** = scivolare oltre
- **gleamed** = risplendere
- **resented** = serbare rancore
- **sturdy** = robusto
- **glared** = fulminare con lo sguardo
- **wrenched** = strappare
- **sat frozen to the spot** = restare impietrito
- **canvas** = tela
- **inched the heavy bucket along** = avanzare lentamente
- **pattering feet** = passi rapidi
- **ladder** = scala
- **rodent** = roditori
- **felt for** = cercare tastando
- **tussled** = azzuffarsi
- **fleshy** = paffuta
- **missus** = signora
- **aiming for** = mirare a
- **outraged** = indignato
- **roared** = ruggire
- **dragged** = trascinare
- **cocky** = arrogante
- **clutching** = stringere
- **tumbled** = precipitare
- **scampering** = sgattaiolare
- **slotting the chisels into** = incastrare, inserire
- **drifted up** = salire
- **Bootlicker** = leccapiedi
- **Portland** = cemento Portland
- **lovingly** = con cura
- **cartwheels** = carriole
- **his face split into a grin** = il suo volto si illuminò con un sorriso

- **lignum vitae** = legno di guaiaco
- **chisel** = scalpello
- **knapsack** = zaino
- **stowed** = riporre, mettere via
- **hoist** = carrucola
- **lashed out** = inveire, attaccare
- **scaffolding** = impalcatura
- **streaked** = scattare
- **flung down** = scagliare, gettare
- **ear-splitting** = assordante
- **docks** = moli
- **uprights** = montanti
- **a tight bundle** = un fagotto stretto
- **a sharp whistle** = un fischio acuto
- **skidding** = scivolare
- **seized hold** = afferrare
- **grasp** = presa
- **peered over** = sporgersi oltre
- **mocked** = prendere in giro
- **sleeve** = manica
- **mallet** = mazzuolo, martello
- **taken against** = prendere in antipatia
- **nick** = rubacchiare
- **sliding backwards** = scivolare all'indietro
- **the butt of his jokes** = il bersaglio delle sue battute
- **vermin** = parassiti, animali nocivi
- **rumble** = rumore
- **gazing** = fissare